

Renaissance mercenaries
Dressed in a flamboyant style that typified the Renaissance era, the Landsknechts were the German answer to the Swiss soldiers of the day. The majority were pikemen, but the elite *doppelsöldners (above)* wreaked havoc with their halberds and double-handed broadswords *(right)*.

GARISHLY-DRESSED LANDSKNECHT mercenaries were a constant presence on the European battlefields of the late 15th and 16th centuries. Fighting as dense formations of pikemen supported by firearms, they were at their best exceptionally tough foot soldiers in combat. Out of battle, however, they could be a danger to all and sundry, especially if their employer failed to keep them adequately paid and fed. Quarrelsome and resistant to authority, the Landsknechts earned a fearsome reputation for plunder and massacre.

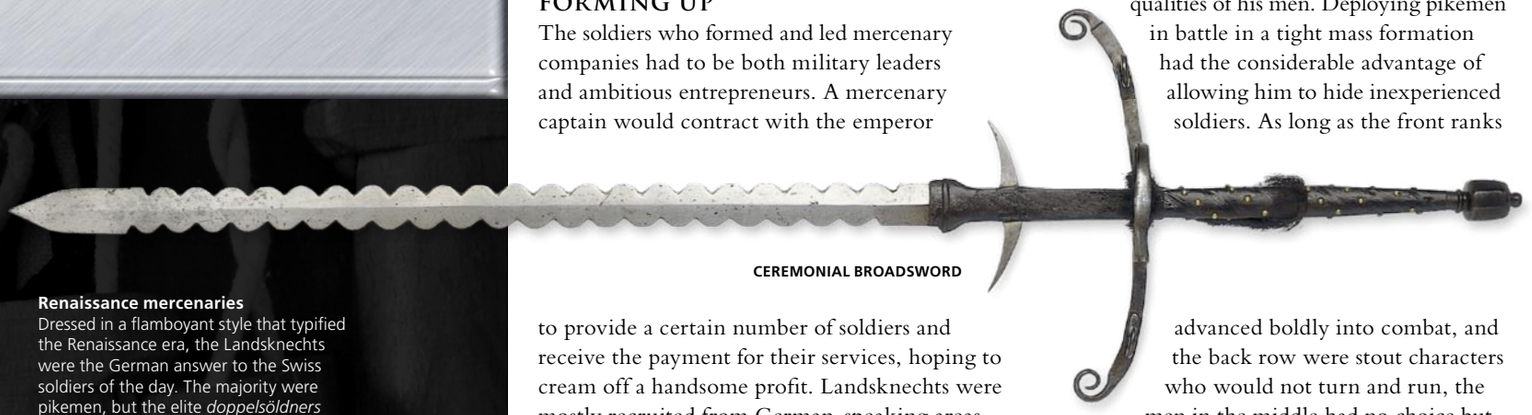
The first Landsknecht bands were raised in 1486, at a time when significant changes were taking place in European warfare. The breakup of the medieval social order was leaving rulers ever more dependent upon mercenary troops, rather than forces assembled on the basis of feudal loyalty or obligation. In France and Burgundy, mercenaries had been taken into permanent employment to form regular armies. At the same time, tactical innovations were questioning the role of heavy cavalry as the shock offensive force on the battlefield. At the battles of Murten and Nancy, in 1476–77, Swiss infantry armed with long pikes won notable victories through attacking their enemy in tight, massed phalanxes. Lacking both a regular army and pike-wielding infantry, German Emperor Maximilian I felt threatened by these military developments. His response was to pay for the formation of Landsknecht ("land servant") bands. These were to be infantry paid as mercenaries, but ready to fight for the emperor when required.

FORMING UP

The soldiers who formed and led mercenary companies had to be both military leaders and ambitious entrepreneurs. A mercenary captain would contract with the emperor to provide a certain number of soldiers and receive the payment for their services, hoping to cream off a handsome profit. Landsknechts were mostly recruited from German-speaking areas of central and northern Europe, such as the Rhineland, Swabia, and Alsace. Men could be attracted from far afield, however, with even Scotland providing volunteers. The immediate lure was the promise of four guilders a month in pay – a reasonable income for the day and immensely tempting to anyone down on his luck. Beyond this there were all the traditional benefits of contemporary military life on offer, from the chance to indulge in looting and pillage to the amusements of a vagabond life rich in adventure and general hellraising.

A potential recruit had to present himself equipped with, at minimum, a 5–6m (16–20ft) long pike. Since such a weapon could be purchased for one guilder – a cheapness that goes a long way to explain the popularity of the pike as an infantry arm – most men were capable of fulfilling this obligation. The better-off might turn up with swords, armour, or even an arquebus. A candidate was traditionally subjected to a simple fitness test, being required to jump over an obstacle made of three pikes or halberds. This done, he was considered fit for service and his name was entered in the roll.

Given these less-than-stringent entrance requirements, the Landsknechts must have been of uneven quality. A successful mercenary captain needed a sharp eye for the individual qualities of his men. Deploying pikemen in battle in a tight mass formation had the considerable advantage of allowing him to hide inexperienced soldiers. As long as the front ranks advanced boldly into combat, and the back row were stout characters who would not turn and run, the men in the middle had no choice but to hold their position and go along with the crowd. The boldest, fiercest fighters were rewarded with double pay – hence their name *doppelsöldner*, which translates as "double-pay men" – and deployed independently to attack with double-handed broadsword or halberd.



CEREMONIAL BROADSWORD